Heart of Oak

Teaching Conservation and Craftsmanship in Japan

BY WENDY MARUYAMA



木木木 Trees. Lots of trees. The transition of traveling by train from the bustling city of Tokyo, teaming with people, a dichotomy of chaos and order, to the green mountainous Gifu prefecture is dramatic. Suddenly it seems as if all the tensions and stress of being in an energetic city has suddenly been replaced by calm. The train winds its way up mountainous terrain, passing waterfalls, and lush green bamboo groves and trees. Gifu prefecture is known in Japan for its woodworking industry and forest programs. I pass several lumber mills, furniture shops, and other wood-related industries just to the side of the train tracks.

Set deep within the mountains of Gifu Prefecture is the wonderful village of Takayama, where a remarkable number of old traditions have been preserved. The history of Takayama begins with its carpenters. Skilled carpenters from the area are said to have built the Imperial Palace in Kyoto, as well as several temples in both Kyoto and Nara. At the end of the 16th century, the Kanamori clan established Takayama Castle, and this was the origin of its culture. The surrounding forests in Hida, as the region around Takayama is called, provide fine timber for building traditional houses and for the simple utensils and lacquerware that have been made here for hundreds of years.

On that train ride to Takayama from Tokyo, I was headed to visit my old friend, Osamu Shoji, the lead professor for Shinrin Takumi Jyuku, the first woodworking school in Japan to incorporate forestry, furniture construction and design, and ecology in its curriculum. I had first visited Takayama in 1996; I was in Japan on a Japan/US Fellowship, and I journeyed to the village on the recommendation of Tom Loeser and Clifton Monteith, previous fellowship recipients. The camaraderie I experienced with my Japanese counterparts, as a furnituremaker and educator, encouraged me to return three times, the latest being in April 2002. What follows is a description of two significant teaching and studio facilities in Takayama and the impact they are having on maintaining traditional Japanese woodworking as well ensuring its survival for the coming generations.

OAK VILLAGE

Nestled in the mountains of Takayama lies a sprawling compound of custom woodshops (one, a furniture production shop and the other, an architectural shop), a retail showroom and store, a cafe, a woodworking museum, offices and an architecture business. This is Oak Village, a unique enterprise which combines craft, tradition, ecology, design, and education with the common theme of





PHOTOS COURTESY OF OSAMU SHOJI, OAK VILLAGE, STEVEN AKANO, AND WENDY MARUYAMA

LEFT TO RIGHT:
The new buildings that house Shinrin Takumi Jyuku, completed in December of 2001.

Tsutomi Uchida, shown as a student, working on his final second-year project. He now works as staff at Takumi Jyuku.

A first-year student planting an oak sapling .

preservation and conservation of nature.

Originally, in 1974, Oak Village was a commune established by three young idealists and environmentalists: Tadashi Inamoto, Osamu Shoji, and Masatoshi Tsukuda. Concerned about the loss of hardwood trees, their business was dedicated to creating an ecology-minded philosophy of replacing what is used to make wooden products. This philosophy, when translated from Japanese, means "A wooden object will last 100 years; since a tree is approximately 100 years old before it's ready to be milled, we plant one tree for each one harvested. When the time comes to rebuild that wooden object, we will have the resources we need." Unlike materials such as iron, aluminum, and plastics, wood is 100% recyclable, environmentally friendly and self-sustainable.

Oak Village began in a modest farmhouse in Hida. Using oak as the main material, it was a made-to-order shop. True hippies in the best sense of the word of that time, Inamoto, Shoji, and Tsukuda forged a livelihood in the mountains, producing furniture and wooden objects. Eventually the business expanded into architecture, making custom houses using traditional Japanese construction techniques.

In 1978, Oak Village organized the first "Summer Seminar" (now "Nature School of the Forest") in an effort to communicate with other communities about the importance of wood and nature. The seminars, an outreach effort called "an acorn for each child," were based on the belief that every individual, from an early age, should be educated to appreciate and to understand the importance of wood, nature, and the environment. The first exhibition of Oak Village's products was held at Kinokuniya Bookstore in Tokyo. Due to the commercial success of that venture, and realizing the need for outreach and exposure to the large cosmopolitan city of Tokyo, a showroom, "Oak Village Tokyo," opened at the bookstore in 1981. "Acorn Club" began as an environmental education organization. The Architecture Department also started and the company's motto, "from a bowl to a house," was solidified.

In 1985, finding and educating young craftsmen became a serious problem for the company. There was a shortage of young people with skills in traditional









CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT:
A team from Oak Village installing a custom wood house, built using traditional timber framing.

The machine room for Takumi Jyuku. Staff members Yuri Kobayashi and Tsutomi Uchida are shown on the right.

Professor Osamu Shoji's personal hand planes and tools.

Custom-designed Oak Village furniture for a restaurant.

woodworking and carpentry; this was compounded by the fact that there were no schools for training in this type of craft. In 1987–1988, "Oak Hearts"—a subsidiary of Oak Village— began as a company with a fully integrated environmental vision. Strong exchanges with other organizations, such as Japan Environmental Education Forum, Inc. and International Crafts Institute, started. Finally in 1991, "Forest Crafts Institute" was established as an educational system to train highly skilled professionals. This is now known as "Shinrin Takumi Jyuku," headed by Osamu Shoji and Masatoshi Tsukuda.

Oak Village is still dedicated to producing superior quality wooden furniture, architecture, goods and accessories. The furniture shops have grown to include custom designs, as well as a production line of chairs, tables, and cabinets. In addition, beautifully-designed small objects—toys, desk accessories, boxes, lacquered trays and turned bowls —are made. Oak Village's task and mission are to produce works that are not only for the current generation but also for the generations of the 21st century. Its highly skilled craftsmen and carpenters, who are well versed in traditional Japanese carpentry, hand craft each Oak Village product from carefully selected wood. In this fast-changing world that quickly consumes and wastes new products and trends, the philosophy of Oak Village remains true to its word and may be the only key to the survival of this trade.

Although I had been to visit Oak Village several times, my first meeting with Tadashi Inamoto was in April 2002. I found him to be engaging, charismatic, and warm. Inamoto is passionate about his role as a natural activist. When asked how he became involved with Oak Village and his concern for the forests, he explained that he initially studied nuclear physics at university and continued in the faculty after graduating. This was around the time that industrial pollution was at its peak in Japan, and people became concerned about the increasing number of environmental problems. One of the most alarming was Minamata Disease, which was officially discovered in 1956 in the communities around Minamata Bay in southwestern Japan. A few years later it was diagnosed as being caused by ingestion of fish contaminated by mercury from a local chemical manufacturing plant. Eating the contaminated fish poisoned 121 people, 46 of whom died. The disease also caused severe birth defects in









CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER RIGHT:
Children's workshops are part of the educational component at Takumi Jyuku. These young students are learning how furniture is made.

Takumi students visit a local sawmill to learn how a log is examined before milling, and how to maximize the use of the timer.

Spring planting of rice.

The fall planting of oak seeds takes place in October and November.

the next generation.

It was at this point that Inamoto felt he needed to shift his priorities to the needs of preserving nature and natural resources. His passion for the preservation of the forests, environmental issues and the planet are evident in conversation and through the many books he has written. He also lectures internationally. His recent publications include *Forest Museum*, *Journey of the Forest, People of the Forest*, and *Form of the Forest, Work of the Forest*, which received a Mainichi Publication Cultural Award in 1996. When I met him he was in the process of finishing up a series of essays about forests around the globe. So far, he has visited Costa Rica, New Zealand, China, and the USA, and is planning future trips to Brazil, England, Canada, and the African continent. These essays are scheduled to be published under the title *Planet of the Forest*.

The creation of the architecture division at Oak Village by Inamoto was inspired by the premise that a renaissance in wooden architecture is possible, and necessary. In Japan, people are becoming more aware of the dwindling traditions of Japanese woodworking, and there is a growing revival of interest in wooden architecture. Universities and the construction industry are trying hard to rectify their past neglect, and have established a forum on wooden construction. Renowned architects have begun to design wooden structures. The history and tradition of Japanese carpentry, on the brink of being lost, is now being revived.

The managing director of architecture at Oak Village is Eiji Ueno, who oversees the designs of both public spaces and private homes. These beautiful homes all incorporate the solid timber frame construction of the old Japanese carpentry tradition, in combination with a modern sensibility. When I visited, the architects' offices were very busy, with several residential projects in process.

The homes are designed and built on the premises. After all the parts have been cut, planed, and joined, each beam is marked and wrapped carefully and delivered to the site. There, the structures are erected piece by piece. Using traditional Japanese techniques, most of the houses are constructed with large vertical columns and horizontal beams. This wooden structure excels others in withstanding strong winds and earthquakes by making use of the flexibility and malleability of wood. When situated in a city, this house is designed with the living room, study and bedrooms surrounding a beautiful courtyard: a peaceful oasis, away from the hustle and bustle of an urban environment. In the case of a summer home, it might stand atop a steep slope, facing the valley of a forest: the







CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT:
First-year students completing a production line of children's furniture.

Second-year students working in teams to assemble furniture from the production line.

First-year students assembling a production line of accessories. All this work will be sold through the retail store to help support the school.

panorama is a sea of greenery and the changing faces of the four seasons. This elicits the experience of living not only in the forest, but with it. Oak Village and its philosophy are embodied in these respectful, resourceful homes.

SHINRIN TAKUMI JYUKU

Founded in 1991, the school grew out of concerns that the craft of woodworking was slowly disappearing with the growth of industrial postwar Japan. At the same time, natural resources were dwindling and steps needed to be taken to replace what was being removed from the forests. Only in the last 100 years had the government instituted a program to replace conifer trees. This did not include hardwoods, however, which were rapidly being depleted.

The name, Shinrin Takumi Jyuku, translates to "Forest Pioneer Craftsman School." Together with Masatoshi Tsukuda, Professor Shoji established the school as an educational institution that uses hands-on experience to teach its students. Masatoshi Tsukuda is the president of Takumi, and oversees the business aspects of the school. His wife Mayumi is also part of the heartbeat of the school. She works as a staff person in the office and, like her husband, has been involved in the program since its inception. She also teaches basketry classes, which are part of the nature program at Takumi, and serves as an interpreter as needed for visiting artists from the United States.

Together with Tsukuda, Shoji developed a curriculum that integrates forest sustenance practices, rice field management and cultivation, woodworking skills, hand tool use, production practices for furniture, and design. The program aims to encourage students to support *ki no bunka* or "wood culture." The school is based around a production workshop, enabling students to acquire practical techniques that are essential in the professional field. It fully embraces the ideology of building a society based on the natural ecological cycle. This establishes Shinrin Takumi Jyuku as a truly unique institution, unlike any other program in Japan or internationally.

The *ki no bunka* program has an extensive course curriculum that reads like a botany course. The study of trees focuses on hardwoods (broad leaf species): their history, identification, sustainability, planting, growth, harvesting, circulation of lumber, and drying practices. In addition, the history of world forests as well as Japanese forests, ecology, and the use of wood in Japanese culture and daily life are taught. A "Man and







CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER RIGHT:
During the evening, demonstrations and lectures are given to the students by Osamu Shoji.

A second-year student shows her model for her final project. All final projects are displayed in the annual exhibitions held in Tokyo and Kiyomi.

Tool maintenance is an ongoing part of the shop ritual for all students. All handplanes are checked and flattened as necessary.

Nature" segment addresses the process of rice cultivation, working towards a sustainable society, and the gifts of nature to man and how man can reciprocate. It is this aspect of Takumi's program that makes it unique.

At the heart of the program is the *monozukuri* or the "making of wood products." The curriculum and training are geared toward the production of large volumes of wood objects, ranging from small frames and boxes to furniture. Efficiency and maintaining a high level of craftsmanship are paramount to the success of the program, and are evident in the finished work in the shop. In addition to the pragmatic focus of production design and fulfilling quotas, there are also the elements of handwork and developing a reverence for traditional Japanese hand tools and their maintenance. It is the balance of production and handcraft that provides the students a grounded experience as woodworkers and makers.

No tuition is charged to attend Shinrin Takumi Jyuku. Instead, students commit to two years of study, in the classroom and working in the shop. The work ethic is impressive: the students put in long hours, six days a week, and in the evening, they attend classes and have their own projects that must be designed and built to fulfill the requirements of the course. Earnings made by the sale of the objects and furniture goes back into the school. The school needs to produce a specific volume of work in order to make the program run effectively. It is the reality of running a business that serves as an ideal model for the students to understand the nature of this profession.

The spirit and commitment that Shoji and Tsukuda have invested in the school was tested several years ago when the original site suffered a devastating fire, completely destroying one of the studios, which housed the offices and Shoji's prized library of woodworking books; the records of the school were also lost. The fire started in the finishing room, and was probably caused by rags that had not been properly disposed of. Fortunately, the fire spared the main studio, which housed the machines and bench areas. The tenacity of Shoji, Tsukuda, and their students overcame this loss, and they spent many weeks salvaging what they could, drying out the water-damaged books that survived, and rebuilding the shop. Relatively quickly, the school was back in operation again. Then, it faced another crisis. In 2000, with very little notice, the area on which the original school was built was scheduled to be razed for the development of a new highway system. Again, Takumi's future was









in jeopardy. Fortunately, Kiyomi Village agreed to build a structure for the school under an agreement that leases the property to the school.

When Shoji and his wife, Hisayo, greeted me at the train station, he was absolutely brimming with excitement. "I can't wait to show you the school!" he said. We drove out of Takayama about eight miles, winding up short roads. All of a sudden, appearing out of nowhere, was a beautiful building, with its sleek, modern curved roof, and large studios. It was a complete contrast to the original school site, which certainly had its charm, and land nearby for its forestry program and a rice field. The new location does not have this space, but the school has developed relationships with residents in the area and has agreements with various property owners to allow students to continue planting and tree cultivation programs and maintenance of rice fields.

The new building is nearly three times the size of the old space. There are large well-lit classrooms upstairs used for lectures. They are also used for weekend craft classes open to the local community, as well as for lectures by visiting artists. Below these rooms are the offices for Tsukuda and his staff. Shoji also has his desk here, but spends most of the time out on the shop floor overseeing the woodworking projects. Adjacent to the office building is a large shop, which is equipped with commercial-grade machinery, designed for large production runs.

The place was like a beehive of activity: every machine on, everyone moving in sync, every person with a specified job. There were about 50 oak chairs in production during my visit, and each was impeccably made: absolutely no corners were cut in the quality of these chairs. They were second-year student projects. In another room, the first-year students were working on several different objects—tape dispensers, boxes, toys, and frames. Again, the quality was very high, with a lead student and staff member carefully checking all the pieces.

An unusual project that senior students work on was developed by Inamoto and Shoji in collaboration with two well-known corporations, Pioneer Electronics and Suntory Whiskey. To begin with, both companies implemented basic guidelines focusing on 3R activities (Reduce, Reuse, and Recycle). Pioneer recognized that in order to realize a recycling society it was essential to reduce the environmental impact of all products. At the same time, Suntory Corporation, Japan's leading distiller, had been searching for a better way to reuse its casks. (Until recently, cask wood used to age whiskey ended its life as fuel to make new casks.) Both Pioneer and Suntory seized the opportunity to join forces with Oak Village and Takumi Jyuku to address these issues.

Craftsmen at Oak Village saw great potential in the fine casks. Filled with the conviction that 100 year-old trees should be transformed into products to serve

CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT:
A display cabinet by teacher Osamu Shoji.

A cabinet of Japanese maple—graduation work by student Rie Yamada.

Two views of the "PM2000" speakers made in collaboration with Pioneer and Suntory.

A Japanese oak fall-front desk by student Toshihiro Nonaka.







CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER RIGHT:
Each student will design and make a stool as part of the first year's program.

A large display cabinet, in native hardwoods, by Osamu Shoji.

Graduating student Hidekazu Yamada's final project; the table is teak and the chairs are Japanese oak.

another 100 years, Tadashi Inamoto and Osamu Shoji fashioned a variety of artistic products, ranging from furniture to houses, using the wood. This concept resonated positively with Suntory, a craftsman of liquor, and Pioneer, a craftsman of sound. With the schools' assistance, Pioneer exploited the wood for its beautiful sound quality. In October 1998, the Pure Malt speaker system S-PM1000-LR became the first product to be sold bearing the Pioneer Environmental Label and was highly evaluated by several audio industry magazines. Pioneer pitched its marketing to people who love fine liquor, natural wood, good music, and the Earth from which it all originated.

Oak Village set about cutting the cask wood and making cabinets using the traditional techniques of Japanese craftsmen, without nails or screws. Next, Pioneer installed a speaker unit in the cabinet. Whiskey cask wood that has aged sufficiently provides excellent acoustics. The wood, used to age whiskey for more than 50 years by absorbing its ingredients, had itself matured. When tapped lightly, the wood makes a warm sound unlike that obtained from freshly-cut wood. With Suntory providing the casks, senior students at Takumi Jyuku building the cabinets, and Pioneer in charge of system configuration, sound adjustments and overall production, this three-way collaborative effort was a guaranteed success.

After admiring the work inside, I drove with my hosts to one of the field work sites where three students were busily and happily working in the rain, in muddy fields, moving saplings which had been laid on their sides during the winter snows and were ready to be planted. Despite the rain and mud, the students seemed to revel in the work. All the saplings had been raised from acorns collected by the students and then stored and planted. The program monitors various forest sustenance projects throughout the area and beyond. The volunteers are continuously transplanting trees from one area to another during the growing season. Each tree is given individual attention as it goes through its growing cycles until it is eventually planted. For instance, I was told about a group that traveled to Mt. Fuji to check on the progress of young trees that had been planted earlier, tend to them and clear weeds. This aspect of forestry is done in collaboration with Gifu Academy of Forest Science and Culture.

To continue the original vision of Oak Village's "Acorn Club," Shinrin Takumi Jyuku and its students organize and maintain the Environmental Education Program that enables people from the

The Procession of *Yatai*





MANY OF THE OLD STREETS of Takayama village still retain the original quality of Old Japan. The district called San-machi Suji, for example, the traditional home of Takayama merchants and sake brewers, has been preserved in almost the same state as it was 200 or 300 years ago. During the 300 years when a samurai family settled and governed the town, unique traditions evolved. Of these, the best known are the Takayama festivals that mark the alpha and omega of rural life. In April, the Sanno Matsuri Festival marks the planting season and, in October, the Hachiman Matsuri Festival celebrates the harvest.

The highlight of the festivals is the procession of elaborate floats, or *yatai*, through the streets. Each one is the creation of a separate guild and, over the years, the guilds have competed to produce the most spectacular float ever. The result is a treasure trove of towering structures, some dating from the 17th century, featuring flamboyant carving and colors, and beautifully costumed dolls displayed in curtained niches. Some *yatai* feature marionettes that are technical marvels.

During the year, the *yatai* are stored in *yatai-kura*, tall, odd-looking structures that are noticeable as you stroll around town. These storehouses are closed to prying eyes, but during a visit to Takayama between festivals you can still get an idea of what you're missing by visiting the Festival Floats Exhibition Hall.

community to understand the depth and importance of nature with the theme of "connecting the forest to their daily life." Participants of this program include children, and activities are centered on trekking through forests, camping and the use of wood materials for craft projects. In addition, Shoji takes his own students on treks and all students are expected to be able to identify every tree that grows within the vicinity.

Students coming out of Shinrin Takumi Jyuku emerge as highly skilled and disciplined makers. Some have remained as staff members and assistants for Shoji; others go on to work for Oak Village's furniture shop and architectural division. Many now have their own shops making custom furniture. Interestingly, the gender makeup of the students is nearly 50/50, and one of Shoji's main assistants is a woman. I found this surprising, since my understanding of Japan is as a still largely patriarchal society. Change is evident in many respects. What was once a dying art form and craft is being revived and retained, at the same time as continuing to bring awareness to the delicate balance in nature and the need for sustenance.

The devotion of Shoji, Inamoto, and Tsukuda as educators and passionate naturalists reaches far and wide—and the preservation of both traditional woodworking techniques and the hardwood forests is a mark of success on the part of Shinrin Takumi Jyuku and Oak Village.

Wendy Maruyama is a furnituremaker and professor at San Diego State University in California, where she heads the furniture design program.